

Developing the Project Charter

DAEN 459 Fall 2025
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Sponsor Interaction (& site visit plan, virtual)

- Establish working cadence with sponsor point of contact (POC)
- Elicit problem statement, success criteria, and constraints
- Identify data sources, access, and approvals (privacy/ethics)
- Draft a site visit plan (objectives, agenda, roles, logistics)
- Document sponsor requirements & draft the site-visit plan statement

Sponsor Meeting Checklist

- **POC & stakeholders:** names, roles, availability, decision authority
- **Problem statement:** business need, current “pain” points, desired impact
- **Scope boundaries:** what is in/out this semester
- **Constraints:** tools, data sharing rules, compliance, timelines
- **Data:** sources, owners, schemas, volumes, access method, refresh
- **Success criteria:** measurable acceptance tests & sponsor sign-off path
- **Risks/assumptions:** access delays, data quality, dependencies
- **Cadence:** biweekly advisor sync; monthly sponsor touchpoint

Site Visit Plan ("template")

- **Objectives:** what questions we will answer, items to cover
- **Agenda:** intros, walkthrough, Q&A, next steps
- **Roles:** facilitator, notetaker, timekeeper, tech lead, liaison
- **Logistics:** date/time, location/virtual link, security clearance/NDA (Zoom protections, such as meeting passcode, waiting room, or only authenticated users, etc.)
- **Artifacts:** sample data dictionaries, system diagrams, process maps
- **Follow-up:** action items, owners, deadlines, evidence of completion

Be Prepared

- Share the agenda in advance.
- Assign speaking roles and topics.
- Prepare focused questions.
- Allow the sponsor to respond fully before asking more.
- **Avoid rushing to solutions:
this project spans the full semester (and the next)!**
- Work as a team — common goals, complementary skills.
- Share the workload — collaborate and contribute equally.
- Ask about unfamiliar terms or acronyms.
- **Don't pretend to understand — ASK!**
- Close with a plan: action items, owners, due dates, and next meeting time.

Project Charter (First Draft)

- Synthesize sponsor inputs into a clear **charter**.
- Define scope, deliverables, risks, and acceptance criteria.
- Build an initial timeline & responsibilities.
- Complete the first draft of the project charter.

Project Charter: Required Sections

- **Authority & accountability** (sponsor sign-off)
- **Objectives & success criteria** (measurable)
- **Scope & boundaries** (in/out of scope)
- **Stakeholders & roles** (team, advisor, sponsor)
- **Assumptions & constraints** (data, tools, compliance)
- **Risks & mitigations** (top 5 with owner & trigger)
- **Deliverables** (code, datasets, diagrams, report, poster)
- **Timeline & milestones** (semester checkpoints)
- **Communication plan** (cadence, channels, decisions log)

Draft Quality Checklist (before you submit!)

- Problem statement concise (<150 words) & testable/empirical
- Draft of a Gantt chart
(representing planned activities against time → this semester)
- Outline success metrics
(e.g., defined: latency, accuracy, time/costs ceilings)
- Data access risks tracked with contingency plan
- Architecture sketch: sources → storage → pipelines → outputs
- Table with roles & RACI
(responsible, accountable, consulted, informed, clear for next 2-sprints)
- Milestones dated; dependencies identified; buffer for unknowns
- Plain language; figures labeled; sources credited

Milestones & Policies

- **1st draft of project charter due:** Fri Sep 19, 5:00 PM.
(submit on Canvas)
- Be aware of late work: keep me posted on your progress and possible delays and reasons.
- Good practice: if necessary rotate meetings/presentations leadership; debrief after each time.
- Suggestion: meet advisor at least biweekly; sponsor about monthly.